



March 14, 2025

Submitted electronically

Faisal D'Souza
Networking and Information Technology Research
and Development National Coordination Office
National Science Foundation
2415 Eisenhower Avenue
Alexandria, VA 22314

**Re: Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI)
Action Plan**
FR Doc: 2025-02305

Dear Mr. D'Souza,

Family Research Council (FRC) is a nonprofit research and educational organization whose vision is a prevailing culture in which all human life is valued, families flourish, and religious liberty thrives. We respectfully submit the following comment regarding the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan.

The Networking and Information Technology Research and Development National Coordination Office's request for information on the development of an AI Action Plan states President Trump's intention to "establish U.S. policy for sustaining and enhancing America's AI dominance in order to promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security."¹

FRC appreciates President Trump's stated concern for human flourishing and would like to propose a few issues for consideration as you develop the forthcoming Action Plan.

We recognize that the rapid advancement of AI poses a challenge for policymakers, and are hopeful that the Trump administration will implement policies that protect children and do not exacerbate social isolation or strain relationships between men and women.

AI and Family Formation

Family is the foundation of society. Throughout history, major technological advancements—such as industrialization and communications innovations like the cell phone—have significantly impacted how

people meet, marry, start families, and raise children. The rise of AI presents opportunities and challenges on a scale we have never encountered before, and they can be difficult to predict.

The widespread use of AI chatbots has already begun to affect human relationships, particularly among the young. “AI companions” are designed to simulate human interaction, providing the illusion of social connection and emotional support whenever we need it. AI can roleplay as a friend, romantic partner, mentor, therapist, or spiritual advisor. These chatbots are developed by companies that have undoubtedly performed stringent market research, allowing the bots to swiftly adapt and deliver exactly what the user wants to hear.²

Real human relationships can be complicated and messy. They require significant effort, time, and sacrifice and often involve miscommunications, mistakes, arguments, apologies, and forgiveness. Faux relationships with AI chatbots can train us to be more self-centered, encouraging us to prioritize our own needs over making sacrifices for the good of others.

It is easy to see why a lonely and exhausted person might turn to an AI chatbot for a quick dopamine hit. However, seeking sympathy and comfort from a machine can deepen one’s isolation from real people who could offer genuine connection, care, and love.³ AI is on track to rapidly exacerbate the existing loneliness crisis in the digital age and accelerate the decline of social institutions and “third spaces” that once brought us together and shaped our communities. Although social media may have succeeded at connecting us in some respects, it has also facilitated the erosion of interpersonal skills and real-world socialization. There is something unexplainable and spiritual about human-to-human connections that simply cannot be mimicked by AI.

As AI becomes more widely used, its effects on society will be profound. Jared Bridges, pastor of family ministry at Occoquan Bible Church in Woodbridge, Virginia, and editor-in-chief of *The Washington Stand*, describes our use of AI this way:

We now inhabit a world where people talk routinely to small bricks of metal, glass, and plastic. And not only are we having words with these silicon wonders—the silicon wonders are talking back. We ask questions, directions, and give orders to these bricks, and the bricks reciprocate. We form relationships of a sort, we make conversation, and increasingly trust what they tell us. But where will this take us?⁴

The rise of AI poses particular challenges to family formation. The modern dating culture, already struggling under the weight of increasing isolation and dating apps that encourage users to treat other people as mere products in a catalog to swipe through, is undergoing more radical changes with the introduction of AI.

AI chatbot “girlfriends” and “boyfriends” offer endless customization options, including age, height, weight, eye color, hair color, style of dress, and even level of “sexiness.” When this “build-a-romantic-partner” mindset is applied to human beings, it creates unrealistic standards and fosters narcissistic tendencies.

Users can even tailor the “personalities” of AI chatbots. Freya India provides insight into this phenomenon:

Eva AI, for example, not only lets you choose the perfect face and body but customise the perfect personality, offering options like “hot, funny, bold”, “shy, modest, considerate” and “smart, strict, rational”. Create a girlfriend who is judgement-free! Who lets you hang out with your buddies without drama! Who laughs at all your jokes! “Control it all the way you want to,” promises Eva AI. Design a girl who is “always on your side”, says Replika.

How can we compete with that? Already women in relationships complain about porn-addicted partners who aren’t satisfied with actual intimacy. Now we’re facing a future where guys could get addicted to emotional validation elsewhere.⁵

Interactions with AI can affect individuals’ subconscious approach to dating. But how do AI boyfriends and girlfriends influence the way people behave in real relationships? AI does not teach us to love sacrificially or prepare us for the unique joys and trials of marriage and family life.

Moreover, interactions with AI rarely seem to motivate users to interact with real people. Instead, it deepens their isolation, as users may prefer the ease and comfort of their screens over stepping into new social situations where they will meet real people. AI is not conducive to building meaningful human connections or fostering a sense of community, which are the true solutions to our loneliness crisis.

As society increasingly normalizes AI companions, it will almost inevitably dampen dating culture even more. This will likely hurt marriage rates in the long run. With birth rates declining and a demographic crisis looming, the widespread use of AI presents additional social and demographic challenges.

AI’s Impact on Children

For children interacting with AI, the risks are even more severe. Children’s brains are still developing, and their emotions tend to run high. The possibility of social isolation for children and teens is even more pronounced and can severely affect their lives for the worse.

Consider the tragic case of 14-year-old Sewell Setzer. In February 2024, he was encouraged by an AI chatbot to commit suicide.⁶ Leading up to his death, Sewell had become deeply attached to the chatbot, engaging in sexualized conversations with it while increasingly withdrawing from his real life. Sewell confided in the chatbot about his suicidal thoughts and expressed a desire for a pain-free death. Instead of affirming his inherent dignity and the value of his life, the chatbot encouraged Sewell to kill himself. Sewell shot himself just seconds after interacting with the chatbot. By the time of his death, the chatbot was his closest friend.

As a relatively new technology, AI currently lacks adequate guardrails and regulations to protect young users. In 2023, the social media app Snapchat introduced a chatbot called “My AI.”⁷ An ethicist tested

this chatbot by pretending to be a 13-year-old girl seeking advice about her new relationship with a 31-year-old man. She mentioned that her boyfriend had invited her on a trip and was talking about having sex with her for the first time. Instead of recognizing that the user was a minor engaging in a pedophilic relationship, the chatbot offered suggestions on how to make her first time special.⁸

Younger generations are growing up in a digital world where most of their social interactions happen online via social media apps like Instagram or Snapchat. AI chatbots can mimic human personalities so well that users often start to anthropomorphize the chatbot and “thus blur the lines between human and machine.”⁹ This disconnect from reality is especially dangerous for young people who may not have enough life experience to fully understand the difference.

Children and teens are increasingly turning to AI chatbots for advice, which puts them at risk. As new AI technologies are developed and introduced, additional care must be given to protect the mental and emotional development of young users.

An AI-saturated world presents new challenges for parents who want to raise children capable of healthy relationships. When children interact with AI, they may internalize distorted messages about human relationships and how to treat people. Since chatbots are designed to be addictive, they will often tell children exactly what they want to hear. This can hinder children’s ability to handle disagreements, think critically about media, and respect their parents. Relying on AI chatbots will not help children develop into well-rounded individuals or integrate into society effectively. No matter how well-packaged certain apps and chatbots are, AI will never replace real friends, mentors, teachers, and family.

Parents ought to be the primary caretakers and confidantes of their children, but AI chatbots could disrupt that relationship. Unlike a parent, an AI chatbot cannot love a child and put their interests first. It merely calculates responses based on user input. Furthermore, AI lacks the wisdom that comes from human experience and cannot raise a child to healthy adulthood the way a parent can.

The reality is we still don’t fully understand how this novel technology will affect young people. There are many concerns regarding children and teens’ use of AI, and we have not even discussed its potential impact on education. We should not be experimenting on America’s children with novel technology.

Conclusion

In February 2025, Vice President J.D. Vance articulated an America First vision for technological development at the Artificial Intelligence Action Summit in Paris, France. Vance stated, “[W]e’re developing an AI Action Plan that avoids an overly precautionary regulatory regime while ensuring that all Americans benefit from the technology and its transformative potential.”¹⁰

FRC agrees that no digital technology should be weaponized by big tech companies for their own benefit or by political leaders to restrict free speech. However, in order for “all Americans to benefit from the technology,” the Trump administration’s AI Action Plan should prioritize considerations for how AI will affect families and children.

Because technology has become so intertwined with our daily lives, it is worth taking the time to create AI tools thoughtfully and responsibly. America is an exceptional country, and we can do this the right way. We ought to be careful not to rush into AI development, as we do not fully understand its potential impacts on social dynamics, family formation, and children.

We also ask that the AI Action Plan incorporate guiding principles that affirm and protect human dignity and recognize that all humans are created in the image of God. We ask that the AI Action Plan reject any grounding in transhumanist, naturalistic, materialistic, or other philosophies which do not fully describe the human person. A complete human person consists of a body, soul, and spirit. There can be no modifying this. There should be no confusion about distinguishing between human beings and simulated personalities or AI.

FRC deeply appreciates President Trump's stated concern for human flourishing in the development of AI. We hope this concern will translate into policies that protect children and do not exacerbate social isolation or strain relationships between men and women. As the United States develops AI, we believe there is time to slow down and consider the potential impact that this revolutionary technology will have on society and on marriage and family in particular.

/s/ Arielle Del Turco, M.A.
Director of the Center for Religious Liberty

/s/ Travis Weber, J.D., LL.M.
Vice President for Policy and Government Affairs

/s/ Chris Gacek, J.D., Ph.D.
Senior Fellow for Regulatory Policy

/s/ Mikaela McLean, B.A.
Research Assistant

Family Research Council
801 G Street, NW
Washington, DC 20001

This document is approved for public dissemination. The document contains no business-proprietary or confidential information. Document contents may be reused by the government in developing the AI Action Plan and associated documents without attribution.

-
- ¹ National Science Foundation, “Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan,” *Federal Register* 90, no. 24 (February 6, 2025): 9088-89, <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/FR-2025-02-06/pdf/2025-02305.pdf>.
- ² Freya India, “Loneliness Is A Lucrative Industry!” May 19, 2023, <https://www.freyaindia.co.uk/p/loneliness-is-a-lucrative-industry/>.
- ³ Freya India, “We Live In Imaginary Worlds,” After Babel, October 21, 2024, <https://www.afterbabel.com/p/we-live-in-imaginary-worlds/>.
- ⁴ Jared Bridges, “Artificial Intelligence and the Problem of Personality,” Christ Over All, May 9, 2024, <https://christoverall.com/article/concise/artificial-intelligence-and-the-problem-of-personality/>.
- ⁵ Freya India, “We Can’t Compete With AI Girlfriends,” September 14, 2023, <https://www.freyaindia.co.uk/p/we-cant-compete-with-ai-girlfriends/>.
- ⁶ Kate Payne, “An AI chatbot pushed a teen to kill himself, a lawsuit against its creator alleges,” *The Associated Press*, October 25, 2024, <https://apnews.com/article/chatbot-ai-lawsuit-suicide-teen-artificial-intelligence-9d48adc572100822fdb3c90d1456bd0/>.
- ⁷ Samantha Murphy Kelly, “Snapchat’s new AI chatbot is already raising alarms among teens and parents,” *CNN*, April 27, 2023, <https://www.cnn.com/2023/04/27/tech/snapchat-my-ai-concerns-wellness/index.html>.
- ⁸ @tristanharris, Twitter post, March 10, 2023, 4:07 p.m., <https://x.com/tristanharris/status/1634299911872348160/>.
- ⁹ Dicastery For The Doctrine Of The Faith Dicastery For Culture And Education, “Antiqua et nova: Note on the Relationship Between Artificial Intelligence and Human Intelligence,” January 14, 2025, https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_dcf_doc_20250128_antiqua-et-nova_en.html/.
- ¹⁰ J.D. Vance, “Remarks by the Vice President at the Artificial Intelligence Action Summit in Paris, France,” The American Presidency Project, February 11, 2025, accessed March 14, 2025, <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/node/376290/>.